



THE FAO DRYLANDS SCHOOL

Training the champions of the world's drylands

A global FAO platform for training, capacity development and the exchange of best practices in dryland forests, rangelands and agrosilvopastoral systems.

INITIATIVE OF FAO COFO Working Group	ESTABLISHED 2022	EDITIONS 4 · 2023–2026	FORMAT 4-day blended course
PER COHORT 20–25 champions	ALUMNI 50+ · 25+ countries	LANGUAGE English	SELECTION Open call

I WHAT IT IS

The FAO Drylands School trains “**champions**” – the planners, practitioners and policymakers who advocate for and operationalize transformative change in the management of dryland forests, rangelands and agrosilvopastoral systems.

An initiative of the **COFO Working Group on Dryland Forests and Agrosilvopastoral Systems** (a subsidiary body of FAO's Committee on Forestry, established 2016), it has run since 2022. Each edition is hosted in a different dryland region with universities, research institutes, UN bodies and the host government, back-to-back with a Working Group session, and supports the **UN International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists (IYRP) 2026**.

1 HOW A SCHOOL WORKS

- 1 eLearning foundation.** Selected participants first complete the FAO eLearning Academy course *Transforming dryland forests and agrosilvopastoral systems* and prepare a case study from their own work.
- 2 Open call & selection.** Partners disseminate an open call; 20–25 champions are chosen on motivation, capacity and potential impact, balancing gender, geography and diversity.
- 3 The four-day school.** A professionally facilitated, English-language course of technical lectures, group work on participants' own case studies and peer-to-peer learning.
- 4 Field day.** A day in the field with local communities and stakeholders – seeing restoration, rangeland and agrosilvopastoral practice first-hand.
- 5 Certificate & network.** Graduates receive a certificate and digital badge, and join the alumni network – a standing community of practice with continued engagement.

2 FOUR SCHOOLS, FOUR DRYLANDS

EDITION	HOST & DATES	THEME
1st • 2023	Amman, Jordan Sep 2023	Transformative approaches in agrosilvopastoral systems
2nd • 2024	Nairobi, Kenya 12–15 Sep 2024	Monitoring restoration in agrosilvopastoral systems for sustainability & ecosystem services
3rd • 2025	Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia 7–10 Jul 2025	Improving the governance of dryland forests, rangelands & agrosilvopastoral systems
4th • 2026 UPCOMING	Adelaide, Australia Jul 2026	Indigenous knowledges & practices in drylands and fire management

3 A GROWING ALUMNI NETWORK

Graduates form a standing, **South–South community of practice** that keeps exchanging knowledge and mentoring new cohorts between editions. The network already spans **more than 25 countries** across Africa, the Middle East, Asia, Europe and Latin America. Explore the full, filterable alumni map on the **DRIP Community page**.

4 PARTNERS

Editions have been delivered with the **UNCCD G20 Global Land Initiative**, **Community Jameel**, **CIFOR-ICRAF**, **WOCAT** (CDE, University of Bern), the **Swedish University of Agricultural Sciences**, the **Agricultural Research Council of South Africa**, the **IYRP Global Alliance**, the GEF-7 **DSL-IP**, the **Kenya Forest Service**, host universities and the governments of Jordan, Kenya, Mongolia and Australia.

HOW TO TAKE PART

Champions are recruited through an open call disseminated by FAO and partners ahead of each edition. To be ready, complete the FAO eLearning course *Transforming dryland forests and agrosilvopastoral systems* and prepare a short case study from your own work in drylands. Calls and selection are coordinated by the **COFO Working Group** secretariat with the host government and partners.

ABOUT THIS BRIEF

A two-page overview of the FAO Drylands School, prepared for the Drylands Restoration Initiatives Platform (DRIP). Full documentation – concept notes, agendas, reports and the alumni roster & map – is on the **DRIP Community page** and its **document repository**.

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Drylands Restoration Initiatives Platform
An FAO COFO Working Group initiative

PARTNERS & AFFILIATION



Food and Agriculture Organization
of the United Nations

Sustainable Forest Management Impact Program on
DRYLAND SUSTAINABLE LANDSCAPES



GLOBAL ENVIRONMENT
FACILITY

Contact & applications: the COFO Working Group on Dryland Forests and Agrosilvopastoral Systems secretariat, FAO.